Text for images- Case Study of Al-Bassa:

In the following case study of the research, I focus on the displaced Palestinian village of Al-Bassa, which until 1948, encompassed more than 30,000 dunams of land with almost 3,000 residents. Al-Bassa was witnessing major urban, social and cultural developments, which were part of the broader processes of Palestinian urban transformations, taking place during the Ottoman and British Mandate periods. Following 1948, similar to other cases in Palestine, al-Bassa's community was displaced, the village was mostly destroyed, and new Israeli towns were constructed on its lands. Today Shlomi's industrial area is built on al-Bassa's historic core, while only seven remaining buildings are still located in the landscape.

Through this case study, I examine what spatial transformations reshaped al-Bassa; and how a permanent settler presence has been established through displacement, fragmentation and erasure of indigenous spatial relations. The aim of this study is not to show what was erased, but to trace the colonial spatial mechanisms through which erasure was produced.

1) I examine the case of al-Bassa by creating counter maps using georeferencing and superpositions to bring historical and present layers of al-Bassa into relation. This includes maps, aerial photographs, reading the remaining structures in relation with historic al-Bassa and present Shlomi, personal testimonies and other forms of indigenous knowledge, and finally colonial planning of plans' documents and bylaws. Through this method which function as a form of spatial excavation, I superimpose the various layers across different spatial scales and different moments in time, to deconstruct the landscape and expose the mechanisms through which the spatial relations were reorganized.

2) A 1942 map of the historic lands of al-Bassa. The built area was surrounded mainly by olive groves and orchards and were mostly Palestinian-owned. Two main roads connected the village to its wider region: one toward Lebanon and the other toward the Palestinian villages in the east. The map shows how al-Bassa was also connected to the wider regional transportation network through the Haifa-Beirut-Tripoli railway, which provided both passenger and commercial connections and positioned al-Bassa within a wider regional network.

3) The superposition, combining historic layers with the current landscape of Shlomi, and Israel's national planning framework, shows the scale and forms of spatial erasure. The former lands of al-Bassa, no longer exists in its original shape, rather became under Israeli ownership, and have been incorporated into different Israeli localities and regional councils such as Shlomi, and the Mateh Asher Regional Council. The two main roads largely retain their historical locations, without the former continuity to Lebanon, and the historic railway has been transformed into a road while a new route has been approved in another location.
4) A zoom in on the historic built area, combined with personal testimonies of al-Bassa's decedents, reveals the houses, religious and public buildings including a local council, a hotel, a clinic and schools which were also attended by students from neighboring Palestinian and Lebanese villages, due to the previously open borders and al-Bassa's regional connectivity. At the same time, new residential areas are seen developing beyond the historic core, such as the areas to the East and South, with public facilities of schools. All these elements are indication of the urban and cultural development of the village before its destruction.
5) A superposition of historic al-Bassa with the current industrial area of Shlomi showing that the village was not simply destroyed, rather exposing the spatial mechanisms through which the urban structure was fragmented and replaced. First noticed are the historic buildings of al-Bassa that got demolished, except for the seven buildings that appear in red. The disproportionate scale of the industrial structures relative to the historic ones. the misalignment between present-day building orientation and the historic urban fabric. The road network has been changed, where the historic commercial main ones were completely erased, and now replaced by a new road network that appears here in grey, connecting different parts of Shlomi, while going over al-Bassa's historic buildings, and infrastructure. Several historic parcels surrounding the village core kept their original boundaries, others including the core itself, was consolidated into a single parcel, erasing the divisions which previously structured the built environment, leaving the remaining structures physically and socially disconnected from one another.